for the 2024 election," he says.

The Gyanvapi mosque in Varanasi, along with the Shahi Idgah mosque in Mathura, have been on the Sangh Parivar's radar for several decades now. After the Babri Masjid demolition of 1992, they have pitched them unambiguously as 'unfinished business', as evinced in the slogan *'Kashi Mathura baaki hai'*. The renewed clamour in Varanasi—incidentally Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Lok Sabha constituency—started after the favourable decision of the apex court in the Ayodhya temple case in 2019. In the Gyanvapi case, the Hindu petitioners contend that a part of an older temple had been demolished by Mughal emperor Aurangzeb in the 17th century to build the mosque. The Muslim side's plea says the mosque predates Aurangzeb and "has been there for thousands of years".

The issue has drawn sharp reactions across the spectrum, right from Yogi's former deputy CM Swami Prasad Maurya to BSP chief Mayawati. Maurya, who switched sides from the BJP to the Samajwadi Party (SP) before the 2022 Uttar Pradesh assembly election, felt ASI surveys shouldn't be limited to Gyanvapi and referred to an alleged Buddhist shrine being demolished to build the Badrinath temple. Mayawati has been more circumspect, cautioning all sides about going down this road in her tweets and warning of a "political conspiracy" to stoke passions before the general election.

The ruling party seems set on its path. State BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi says, "Whatever Yogiji says is the truth. We believe his words are based on historical facts." It's a line that has paid the BJP rich dividends in the past, and there's no reason for them to believe things have changed. ■

ANI



SIMMERING TENSIONS
Gutted vehicles after the violence in Nuh, Aug. 1

HARYANA COMMUNAL CLASHES

A SCRIPT CATCHES FIRE

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Taunts via videos gone viral on the social media. Counter-taunts by those picking up the gauntlet. Rumour, suspicion, word of mouth and buzzing message platforms blending into each other and raising temperatures all around. And the logical culmination: armed stormtroopers within a religious procession, a concerted attack by local vigilantes equipped with an array of munitions, widespread arson and retaliation. The events, spread out over two days in the vicinity of national capital New Delhi, brought life to a standstill in south Haryana, along with neighbouring districts in eastern Rajasthan and western Uttar Pradesh.

Even before the cops could rein in the rampaging mob in Nuh, where the violence began during a religious procession organised by the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) on July 31, communal clashes had spread to Gurugram, where rioters burnt a mosque and killed a cleric, leaving another person severely injured, the same night. The toll till now: six people dead, including two home guards, over 100 injured, several private and patrol vehicles gutted, as also a string of commercial and residential properties.

To contain the spread of violence, the Haryana government suspended internet services in 14 districts and imposed restrictions on 'unlawful assembly'. Neighbouring states, including Delhi, were also on high alert. State home minister Anil Vij says over 40 FIRs have been registered, and raids are